SECTION 7
Evaluating Significance – Examples

7.1 Archaeological Cultural Landscape of Carnuntum, Austria

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Location and surroundings

The archaeological cultural landscape Carnuntum is located in the east of the province of Lower Austria, close to the border with Slovakia and extends directly south of the Danube over the communities of Petronell-Carnuntum and Bad Deutsch-Altenburg. It is situated between the western outskirts of Petronell in the west, the Danube river in the north, the Pfaffenberg hill in the east and the large agricultural areas in the south. With the gradual incorporation of the Eastern Alps and Danube region into the Roman Empire during the reign of Emperor Augustus (27 BC-14 AD), the area around Carnuntum became a hub for the connection between Northern and Southern Europe. Its location on the northern border of the Roman Empire formed by the Danube and the so-called Amber Road was decisive for this.

Carnuntum is the easternmost site of the Austrian section of the Danube Limes, which is part of the Frontiers of the Roman Empire World Heritage Site. The Austrian Limes section is about 357 km long and runs along the river Danube from the border of Germany (Bavaria) close to Passau through Upper and Lower Austria and Vienna to the area east of Hainburg/Wolfsthal beside the Slovakian border and the city of Bratislava. The first demarcation line of the Danube Limes came into existence when the frontier territory was turned into official Roman provinces around AD 40. For over 400 years this fortification system was the outer borderline of the Roman Empire, protecting it from the tribes to the North.

The frontier system in Austria consisted of a chain of fortifications along the south bank of the river Danube using the river as an additional obstacle and as a communication, supply and trade route. Along the course of the river lay legionary fortresses, forts, fortlets and watchtowers. The individual military installations and other ancillary features were linked by a supra-regional road, the Limes road. Besides the fortresses, forts and fortlets existed civil settlements and cemeteries.

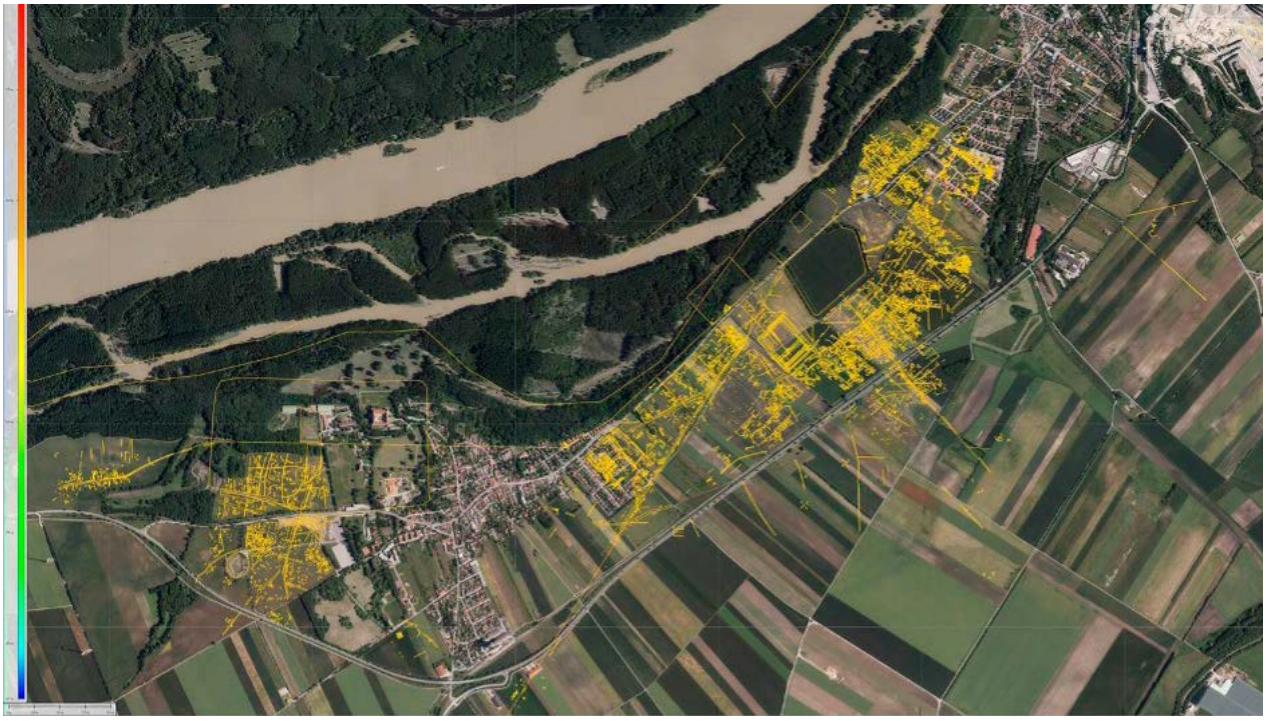

Figure 13: Area of ancient Carnuntum with areas prospected by geophysics and partial interpretation of prospection results. © 7reasons Medien GmbH / LBI ArchPro.

Reasons for assessment

Since 1977, individual areas of Carnuntum have been placed under monument protection. These include the legionary fortress, the auxiliary fort, the so-called Heathen's Gate (Heidentor), parts of the canabae legionis, the two amphitheatres and parts of the civil town.

It was planned for a long time to place all the free archaeological areas of Carnuntum under monument protection, which failed due to the lack of knowledge of the exact extent. Within the framework of the research project "ArchPro Carnuntum", which was carried out from 2012 to 2015, the Roman city area of Carnuntum (more than 10 km²) was completely prospected with geophysics under the direction of the Ludwig Boltzmann Institute for Archaeological Prospecting and Virtual Archaeology (Fig.13). The result was a complete layout of the ancient city with its entire infrastructure, such as roads and water pipelines, as well as numerous farmsteads and temporary camps around the town.

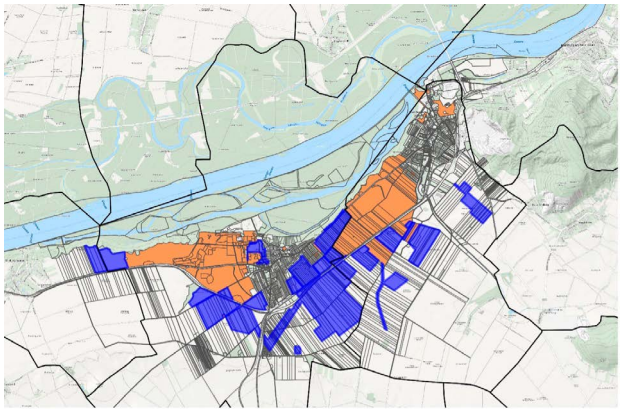

Figure 14: Archaeological cultural landscape Carnuntum: areas under monument protection (orange = before 2019; blue = new areas 2019). © Austrian Federal Monuments Authority

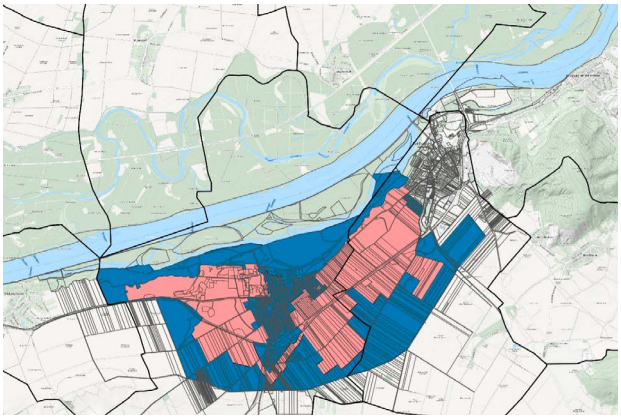

Figure 15: World Heritage Site "Frontiers of the Roman Empire – The Danube Limes (Western Segment)", ID 1608bis-071, Carnuntum (red = property, blue = buffer zone). © Austrian Federal Monuments Authority

One of the main reasons for the protection was the forthcoming submission of the Danube Limes in Bavaria, Austria, Slovakia and Hungary as a UNESCO World Heritage Site. By ratifying the World Heritage Convention, each State Party agrees to preserve its World Heritage Sites with the highest level of national protection. Therefore, the site was added to the 2019 official annual list of monuments to be assessed for the status of protection by law. The assessment of the site was carried out in the same year, followed by an expert report. The protection status was proclaimed by notice from the Federal Monuments Authority on 3 October 2019. There were some appeals against the decision by landowners. After several negotiations at the Federal Administrative Court, the last parts of the archaeological cultural landscape Carnuntum were finally legally listed in 2022 (Fig.14).

Since July 2021, Carnuntum has been on the World Heritage List as a component part of the World Heritage Site "Frontiers of the Roman Empire – The Danube Limes (Western Segment)" (Fig.15).

Description of site

The centre of ancient Carnuntum comprises the area between Petronell and Bad Deutsch-Altenburg, where the legionary fortress with the surrounding military settlement (canabae legionis) and the auxiliary fort are located. To the east of this was the town hill with its sanctuaries (Pfaffenberg). To the west, in Petronell, was the walled civil town, adjoined to the west and south by the civil suburbs, which reached almost as far as the Heidentor (Heathen's Gate) to the southwest. Carnuntum's burial grounds were located along several exit roads leading out of this core zone. The water pipelines coming from the west and south served to supply the legionary fortress and the town with water. Numerous temporary camps and some farmsteads have been found around the core zone.

The oldest verifiable traces of Roman settlement in Carnuntum date back to the middle of the first century AD, when the legio XV Apollinaris was transferred to the Danube and established its base in Carnuntum. An extensive settlement (canabae legionis) subsequently developed around this legionary fortress. About 1.2